

COMPLETE CHESS LEARNING LIBRARY

The Complete Ruy Lopez

From first principles to theory, structures, and practical mastery

TRAINING WORKBOOK

30 focused chapters - model positions - decision rules - retrieval practice

Designed to change what you notice, calculate, remember, and do at the board.

Workbook Method

Attempt each page before reopening the matching course-book chapter. Speak answers aloud or write them. The self-score rewards a clear decision rule and the opponent's best reply, not a lucky move guess.

REVIEW THRESHOLD

8-10: review in one week. 5-7: review tomorrow. 0-4: reread the course chapter now, then retry from a blank board.

Use the workbook again after a game reaches a related structure. Real-game retrieval is the final test.

01. Classical Closed Ruy Tabiya



04 - Closed Ruy Lopez

POSITION PROMPT

The classical Spanish center remains closed while both sides prepare a timed central break.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. h3

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

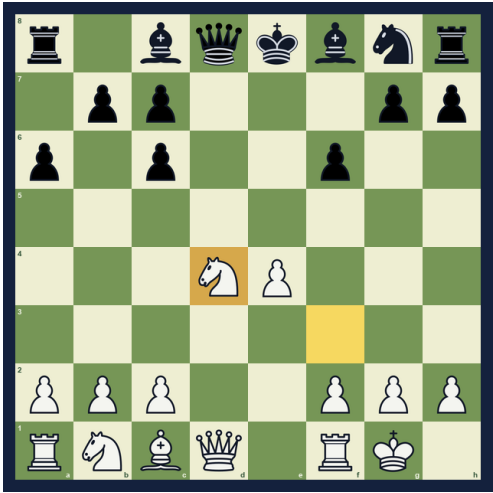
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

02. Exchange Variation with O-O



02 - Exchange and Berlin

POSITION PROMPT

White gives the bishop pair to damage Black's queenside structure and simplify the center.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Bxc6 dxc6 5. O-O f6 6. d4 exd4 7. Nxd4

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

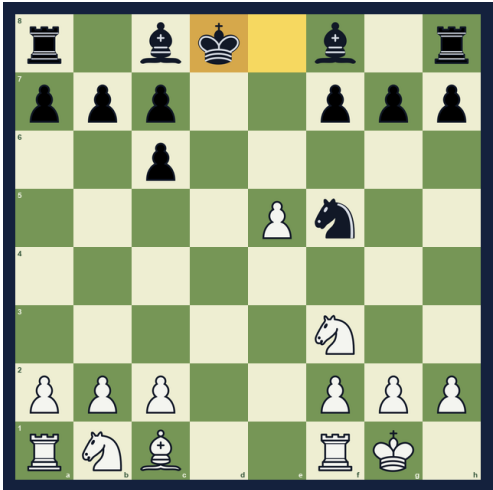
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PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

03. Berlin Endgame



02 - Exchange and Berlin

POSITION PROMPT

Queens leave early, but the uncastled black king is often safe and the position remains strategically rich.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 Nf6 4. O-O Nxe4 5. d4 Nd6 6. Bxc6 dxc6 7. dxe5 Nf5 8. Qxd8+ Kxd8

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

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FORECAST	__ / 2

04. Anti-Berlin 4.d3



02 - Exchange and Berlin

POSITION PROMPT

White keeps queens and avoids the forcing Berlin endgame while retaining a flexible center.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 Nf6 4. d3 Bc5 5. O-O d6 6. c3 O-O

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

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5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

05. Open Ruy Lopez



03 - Open Ruy Lopez

POSITION PROMPT

Black takes e4 and opens the center before completing development.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Nxe4 6. d4 b5 7. Bb3 d5 8. dxe5 Be6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

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- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

06. Open Ruy Dilworth Attack



03 - Open Ruy Lopez

POSITION PROMPT

Black sacrifices or grabs on f2 to create forcing activity against White's king.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Nxe4 6. d4 b5 7. Bb3 d5 8. dxe5 Be6 9. c3 Bc5 10. Nbd2 O-O 11. Bc2 Nxf2

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

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FORECAST	__ / 2

07. Closed Ruy Chigorin



04 - Closed Ruy Lopez

POSITION PROMPT

Black gains queenside space with ...Na5 and ...c5 while White prepares the central break.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. h3 Na5 10. Bc2 c5 11. d4 Qc7 12. Nbd2

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

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PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

08. Closed Ruy Breyer



04 - Closed Ruy Lopez

POSITION PROMPT

Black voluntarily retreats the c6-knight so it can reinforce e5 from d7.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. h3 Nb8 10. d4 Nbd7

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

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PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

09. Closed Ruy Zaitsev



04 - Closed Ruy Lopez

POSITION PROMPT

Black develops the bishop actively and increases pressure on e4 before retreating the other bishop.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. h3 Bb7 10. d4 Re8 11. Nbd2 Bf8

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

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10. Closed Ruy Karpov System



04 - Closed Ruy Lopez

POSITION PROMPT

Black uses ...Nd7 and ...Bf6 to reinforce e5 with a compact but slightly passive setup.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. h3 Nd7 10. d4 Bf6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

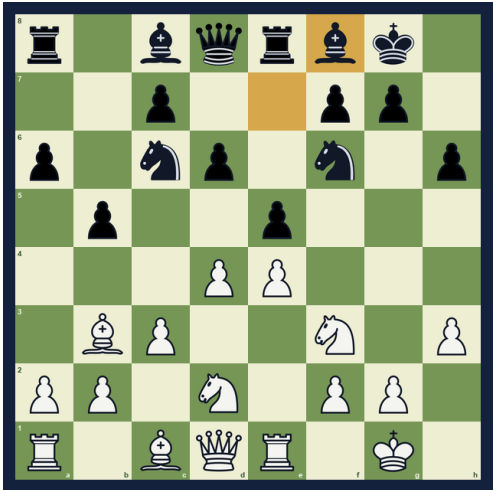
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FORECAST	__ / 2

11. Closed Ruy Smyslov



04 - Closed Ruy Lopez

POSITION PROMPT

Black spends ...h6 to prevent Ng5 and then builds the familiar ...Re8 and ...Bf8 shell.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. h3 h6 10. d4 Re8 11. Nbd2 Bf8

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

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FORECAST	__ / 2

12. Closed Ruy Kholmov



04 - Closed Ruy Lopez

POSITION PROMPT

Black exchanges the Spanish bishop and gives White a semi-open a-file plus doubled b-pawns.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. h3 Be6 10. d4 Bxb3 11. axb3

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

13. Marshall Attack



05 - Marshall and Anti-Marshall

POSITION PROMPT

Black sacrifices a pawn to accelerate every piece toward White's king.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 O-O 8. c3 d5 9. exd5 Nxd5 10. Nxe5 Nxe5 11. Rxe5 c6 12. d4 Bd6

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?
-
2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.
-
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-
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-
5. What ending would favor you, and why?
-

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FORECAST	__ / 2

14. Anti-Marshall 8.a4



05 - Marshall and Anti-Marshall

POSITION PROMPT

White prevents the clean Marshall move order and fixes the queenside structure with a4.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 O-O 8. a4 Bb7 9. d3 Re8 10. Nbd2 Bf8

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

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PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

15. Anti-Marshall 8.h3



05 - Marshall and Anti-Marshall

POSITION PROMPT

White removes ...Bg4 ideas and keeps c3 in reserve to discourage a prepared Marshall.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 O-O 8. h3 Bb7 9. d3 Re8

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

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- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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THREAT	__ / 2
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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

16. Anti-Marshall 8.d3



05 - Marshall and Anti-Marshall

POSITION PROMPT

White avoids the gambit and chooses a slow structure without committing c3.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 O-O 8. d3 d6 9. a4 Bb7

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

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PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

17. Archangel with ...Bb7



06 - Archangel Systems

POSITION PROMPT

Black develops both bishops actively and delays ...Be7 to increase immediate pressure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O b5 6. Bb3 Bb7 7. d3 Bc5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

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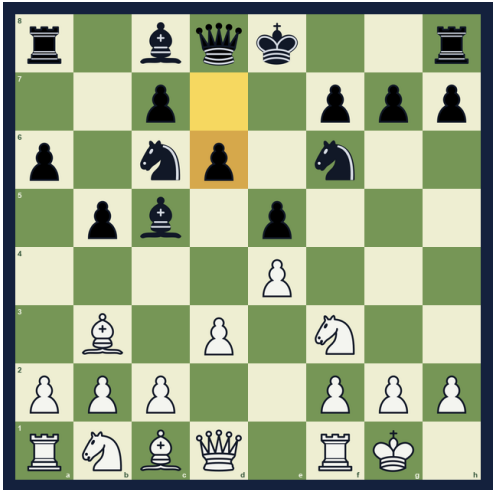
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FORECAST	__ / 2

18. Neo-Archangel with ...Bc5



06 - Archangel Systems

POSITION PROMPT

Black places the bishop on c5 immediately and accepts a more exposed queenside.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O b5 6. Bb3 Bc5 7. d3 d6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

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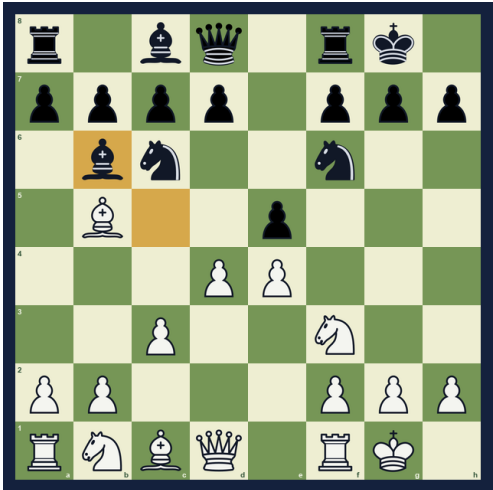
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PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

19. Classical Cordel Defense



07 - Early Black Sidelines

POSITION PROMPT

Black develops naturally without ...a6 and invites White to build the center.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 Bc5 4. c3 Nf6 5. O-O O-O 6. d4 Bb6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

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PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

20. Schliemann Defense



07 - Early Black Sidelines

POSITION PROMPT

Black immediately attacks e4 with the f-pawn and accepts king-side loosening.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 f5 4. d3 fxe4 5. dxe4 Nf6

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

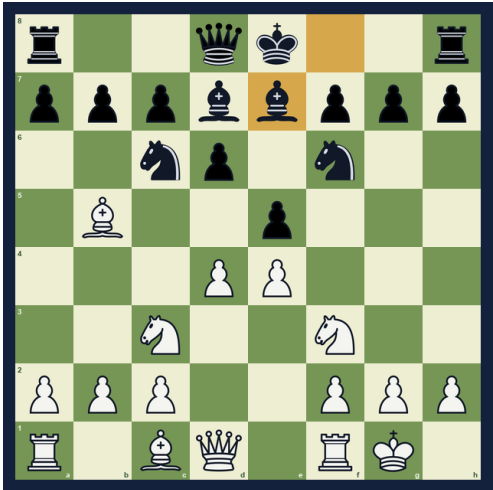
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5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

21. Steinitz Defense



07 - Early Black Sidelines

POSITION PROMPT

Black defends e5 solidly but restricts the dark-squared bishop.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 d6 4. d4 Bd7 5. Nc3 Nf6 6. O-O Be7

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?
-
2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.
-
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?
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4. Which piece has the least useful job?
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5. What ending would favor you, and why?
-

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THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

22. Deferred Steinitz



07 - Early Black Sidelines

POSITION PROMPT

Black inserts ...a6 before adopting the Steinitz shell.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 d6 5. d4 Bd7 6. Nc3 Nf6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

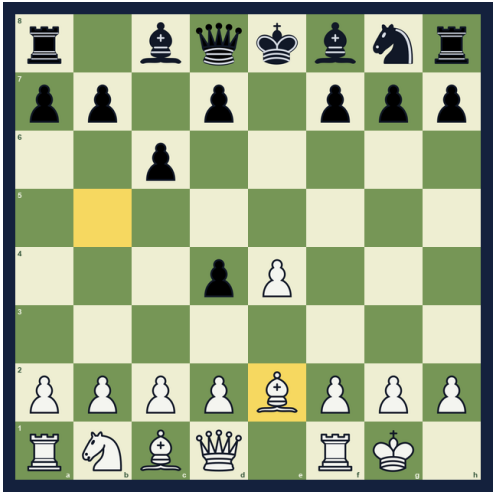
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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

23. Bird Defense



07 - Early Black Sidelines

POSITION PROMPT

Black centralizes the knight and accepts a structurally unusual recapture.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 Nd4 4. Nxd4 exd4 5. O-O c6 6. Be2

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

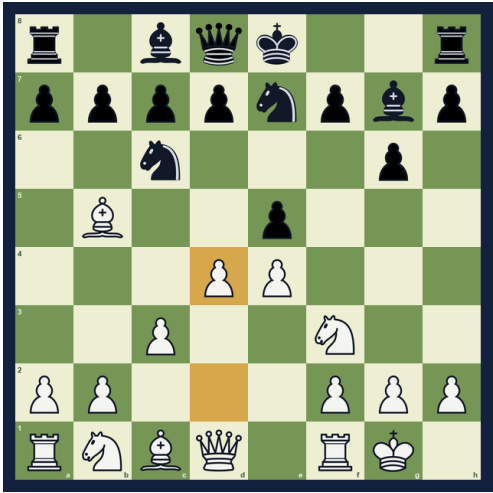
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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

24. Cozio Defense



07 - Early Black Sidelines

POSITION PROMPT

Black develops the g8-knight to e7 and often prepares a kingside fianchetto.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 Nge7 4. O-O g6 5. c3 Bg7 6. d4

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

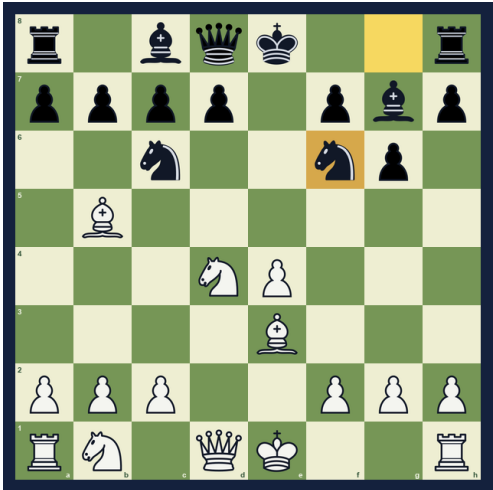
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4. Which piece has the least useful job?

5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

25. Fianchetto Defense



07 - Early Black Sidelines

POSITION PROMPT

Black immediately fianchettoes and pressures the long diagonal.

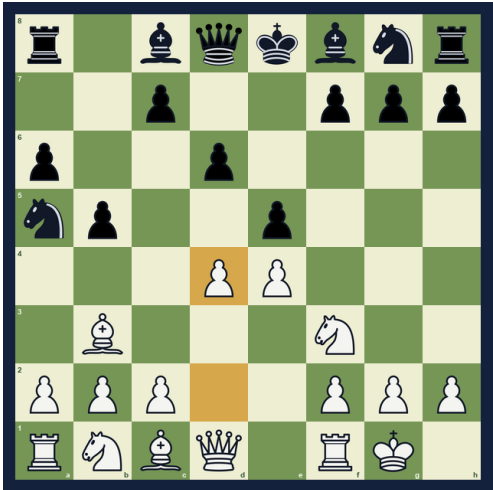
REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 g6 4. d4 exd4 5. Nxd4 Bg7 6. Be3 Nf6

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?
-
2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.
-
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?
-
4. Which piece has the least useful job?
-
5. What ending would favor you, and why?
-

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

26. Norwegian Defense



07 - Early Black Sidelines

POSITION PROMPT

Black spends time to exchange the Spanish bishop with ...Na5.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 b5 5. Bb3 Na5 6. O-O d6 7. d4

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

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CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

27. Worrall Attack



08 - White Systems and Transpositions

POSITION PROMPT

White supports e4 with the queen and keeps the rook flexible.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Qe2 b5 7. Bb3 O-O 8. c3 d6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

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THREAT	__ / 2
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PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

28. Center Attack



08 - White Systems and Transpositions

POSITION PROMPT

White opens the center immediately and gains space with e5.

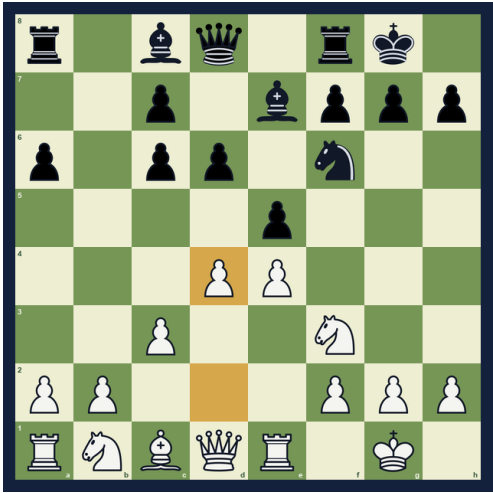
REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. d4 exd4 7. e5 Ne4 8. c3 d5

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?
-
2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.
-
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?
-
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SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

29. Delayed Exchange



08 - White Systems and Transpositions

POSITION PROMPT

White waits until Black commits before exchanging on c6 and changing the structure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 O-O 7. c3 d6 8. Bxc6 bxc6 9. d4

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?
-
2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.
-
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?
-
4. Which piece has the least useful job?
-
5. What ending would favor you, and why?
-

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

30. Pilnik d3 System



08 - White Systems and Transpositions

POSITION PROMPT

White keeps the center closed with d3 and delays the main d4 confrontation.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. d3

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

Monthly Retention Audit

Select ten random chapters and complete them under a ten-minute total limit. Track the categories you repeatedly miss: threat, candidate, structure, piece job, or forecast.

Do not restart the entire course. Return to the smallest group of chapters that repairs the repeated error, then test again in one week.